

MAPPING HABANA



THESE FIELD NOTES DOCUMENT THE HABANA STUDIO **FIELDWORK**
COMPILED IN 2018 THROUGH HABANA LAB AT THE NEW SCHOOL.
THIS PRELIMINARY RESEARCH DIRECTLY INFORMED THE
INTERACTIVE MAPS, VISUALIZATIONS, AND FINDINGS FEATURED ON
OUR WEBSITE.



INTRODUCTION: HAVANA STUDIO

Of all Latin American countries, Cuba and Venezuela seem to be the ultimate standard-bearers of anti-imperialist sentiment. This is why I was so surprised to encounter American flags all over the capital, and even people who had covered their cars with US flags.

More than once I heard in Havana, “I like the people of the US, not the government,” as an explanation for this apparent contradiction. This experience reminded me of the multiple narratives that coexist within people. Had it not been for my interactions with the Habaneros, I would have missed the diversity of opinions that the official narrative of Cuban-US relations fails to convey.

The expression of such political opinions takes place in the private realm—where people feel entitled to their personal views—rather than in spaces where the government imposes an official narrative, such as museums, television, or radio. Nevertheless, there are areas where official history and lived experience (historicity) intersect. These areas are public spaces, continuously shaped by the private realm through performance, poetry, visual art, graffiti, clothing, conversations, architecture, and even clotheslines. It is within the public space that social tension and heterogeneity emerge, contrasting sharply with the one-dimensional narratives produced by the state.

One key space where the public meets the private is architecture—specifically, building facades. It is here that people express their personal history, aesthetic tastes, political affiliations, and everyday lives. These facades serve as one of the few bastions in Cuba where people can express dissent openly: a canvas where public and private tensions clash, and where official state narratives are confronted by the lived experiences of Cubans. Therefore, imposing heritage restrictions or prioritizing specific colonial or modern styles during restoration risks backfiring, as it erases the lived experiences and historicity expressed on these walls.

No one should be forced to praise a specific architectural typology or history when basic material needs remain unmet. Habaneros have adapted colonial homes, modern structures, and contemporary buildings into spaces worthy of admiration that reflect their resilience and determination. Nevertheless, structurally damaged and inadequate housing (as described by residents in Regla) remains a critical problem in the community. As a first step to address this, conducting a survey is a promising approach; however, its methodology must include inner courtyard spaces (ciudadelas) and de-emphasize traditional aesthetic criteria in favor of lived reality.

Although these reflections emerged after the survey had already been conducted, we hope this work serves as a stepping stone toward future plans—ones that build directly upon the creativity and strength of the community, equipping residents with the tools and information needed to improve their own lives.



“Preservation can result in a new process of homegeneiziation and colonization rather than a canvas of popular expression.”

Bennett Donine - Researcher





REGLA: 167 325h aprox.
AREA SURVEYED: 40 000H APROX.

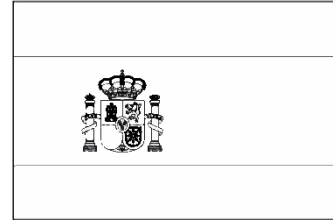
NUMBER OF BLOCKS: 438
SURVEYED: 45

NUMBER OF PLOTS: 13,000
SURVEYED: 600

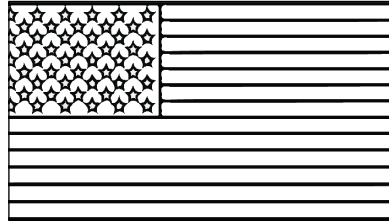
NUMBER OF STRUCTURES: TBD
SURVEYED: TBD

NUMBER OF FACADES: 9,672
SURVEYED: 848

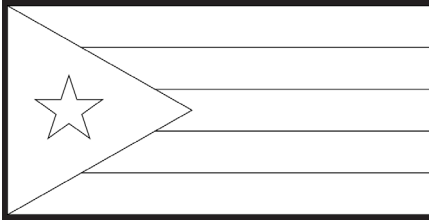
1492–1898



1898–1902



1902

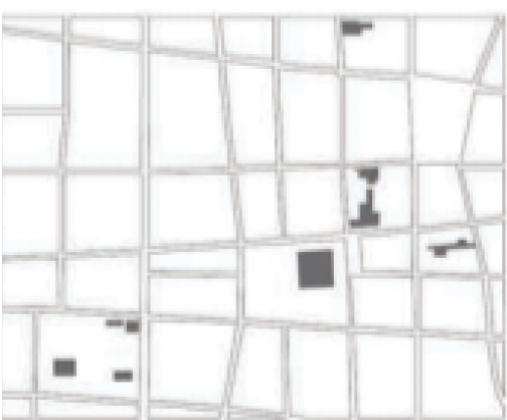
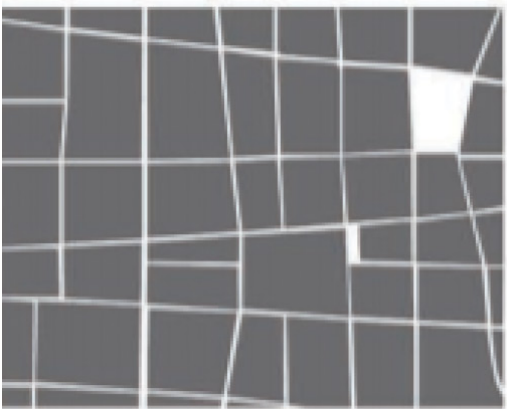


1959-1989



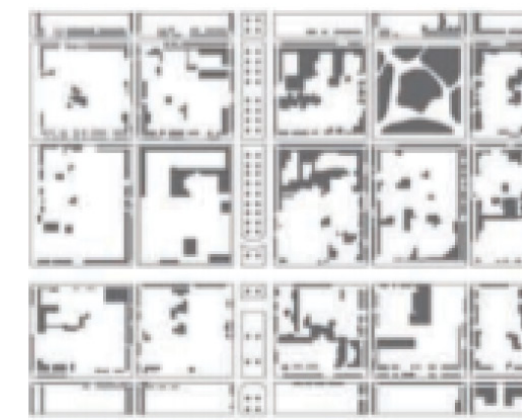
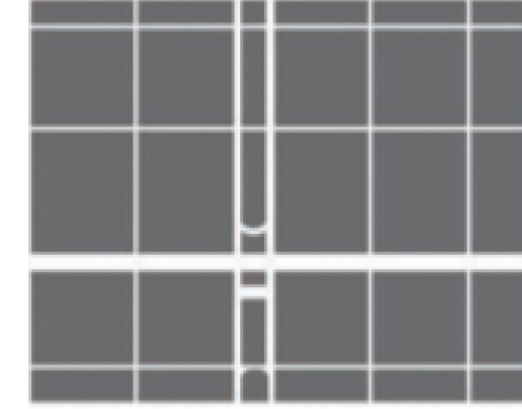
Priodo Colonial

Barroco



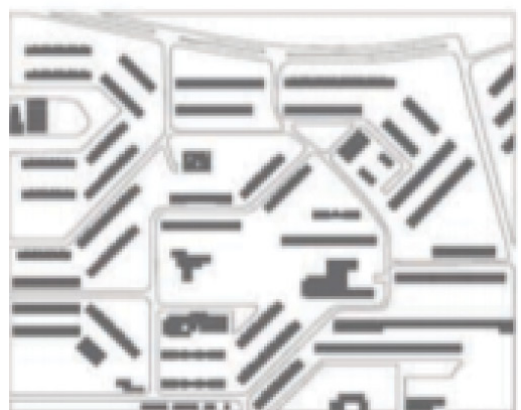
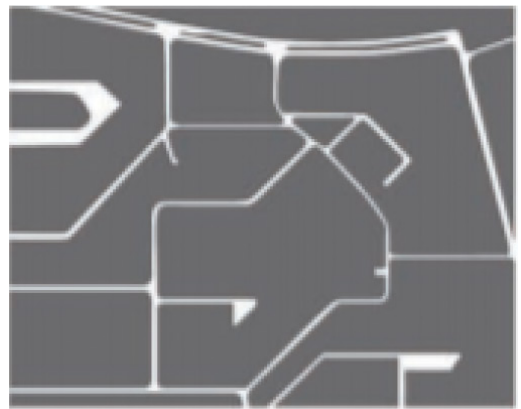
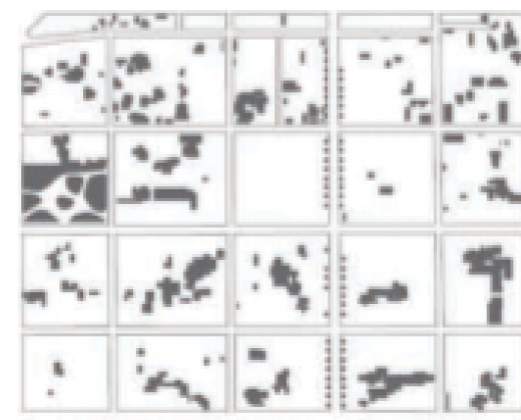
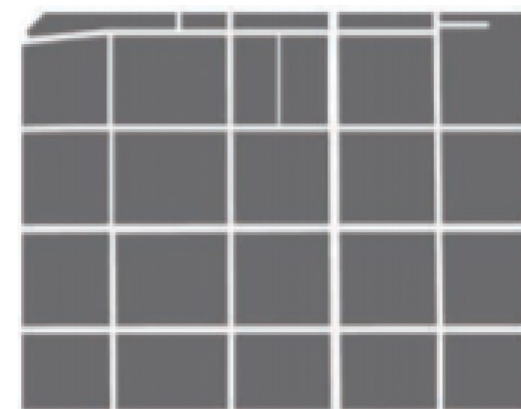
Priodo Republicano

Racional



Priodo Socialista

Utopico



Traza de Regla

Traza de Regla

RANDOM FIELD NOTES ON THE FOR THE CLASSIFICATION

Please consider these pages as impromptu reflections—unfiltered scribbles, visual observations, and personal conversations rather than a finished thesis. They document the dynamic, lived reality of the moment to provide open-ended context for future community-driven work.

ARCHITECTURE THAT FALLS OUTSIDED THE TYPOLOGIES PROPOSED



“from serious and necessary architecture before the 80’s into extravagant neoliberal architecture” fuck the context... now a new change reverting to context because of environment (forced ecology)



“change the context, re-signify the building, or change the structure that signifies it, e.g. from government to people”

“preservation did not involve changing architecture, but changing the way that architecture was perceived” michailovviski



“history uses the category of “form” to simultaneously invoke a buildings physical properties and elevate these data into historical bastractios”

“effects of time on architecture matter were visible but not necessarily legible”



“oma was not ocmissioned to change the buildings, but to reframe how the public perceives them”



“the formless defines a system of interacting dependencies. It may eventually produce geometry, but does so by embodying constraints and responding to changing conditions, with the design process itself understood as a holistic equilibrium.”



“to undermine forms central, organizational role in architecture is to encourage the collapse of certain entrenched disciplinary hierarchies and structures – a whole range of repressive tendencies that cohere around the many sense of architectural form.”



“human interventions –weather further damage or restoration—were perceived and performed as a break in this historical continuum” (narrative, institutional)

“a matter f perception and history... shift in percetual apparatus, making htem structural to the development of art, and indexint htem by changes in the relative wight fiven to obnective and sybjective viesws of arst-ists and their audiences”

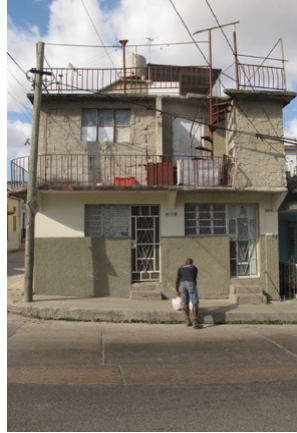


“where historic value once demanded that monuments be seen (and preserved) as documents of a specific historical period, age value instead detaches monumentality from any specific reference to the moment when the object was made, arising instead from the psucho-logical feeling provoked by the passage of time” ... the natural object doenst recongnise when it was shaped or put into the structure history historicity

“...partially autonomous implemented design processes. Here the formless may be referred to as the replacement to direct manipulation of geometry with an aprocedural design process, in which the designer does not look for a single formal solution instead reimagines the design as the current state of an evolving system of constraints, working through design discoveries made within this dynamic system”

“At the level of experience, the unfolding duration of an encounter with a building is compressed into a single moment of recognition or comprehension of the buildings form. Over the life span of a building, its form is posited as a static entity.”

“but more than any process, the formless is about producing and occupying a certain status in relation to form and ideas. It is about having the result in the first thought, the whole building in the first sketch or the entire experience in a single moment. It is about resisting the certainties of formal narratives, subverting classification, and disrupting coherence. The formless doesn’t add up”



CATEGORIES PROPOSED BY THE RESEARCH TEAM



MAMPOSTERIA HISTORICA



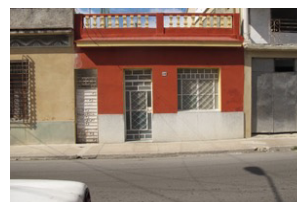
MODERNISTA CUBANO



MADERIA HISTORICA



ARQUITECTURA DE NECESIDAD



RENOVACION POPULAR



ARQUITECTURA CIVICA/ INDUSTRIAL



ARQUITECTURA RELIGIOSA



MAMPOSTERIA HISTORICA

HISTORIC MASONRY

GROUND-FLOOR COMMERCIAL

PLANTA BAJA COMERCIAL



ARQUITECTURA RELIGIOSA

RELIGIOUS ARCHITECTURE

RELIGIOUS ARCHITECTURE

VIEW OF INTERACTIVE MAP TO EXPLORE THE STREETS

Tipologías / Typologies

La necesidad por construir hogares para sus familias ha llevado a los habitantes de la capital a modificar cientos de estructuras. Este es un acto de resiliencia al que han sido empujados muchos cubanos que al verse limitados por recursos económicos y materiales. Las fachadas se convierten así en mosaicos que revelan las diferentes etapas constructivas de cada edificio. En un intento por visualizar este fenómeno, llevamos a cabo un análisis que busca que buscan descomponer este complejo fenómeno. Identificamos 4 tipologías de la base estructural que determina cada edificio: Colonial/Neoclásica, Madera, Modern y Contemporáneo.

Contemporáneo Contemporary

Mampostería Masonry

Otros Other

Moderna Modern

Madera Wood

4, 4%

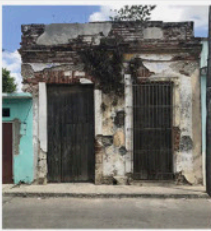
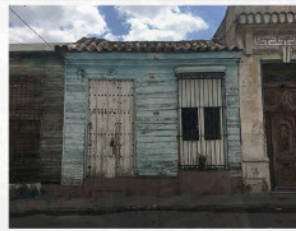
8, 8%

6, 6%

58, 59%

23, 23%

The need to build homes for their families has led the inhabitants of the capital to modify hundreds of structures. This is an act of resilience to which many Cubans who have been limited by economic and material resources have been pushed. The facades thus become mosaics that reveal the different construction stages of each building. In an attempt to visualize this phenomenon, we carry out an analysis that seeks to decompose this complex phenomenon. We identified 4 typologies of the structural basis that determines each building: Colonial / Neoclassic, Wood, Modern and Contemporary.



ABOUT

MAP

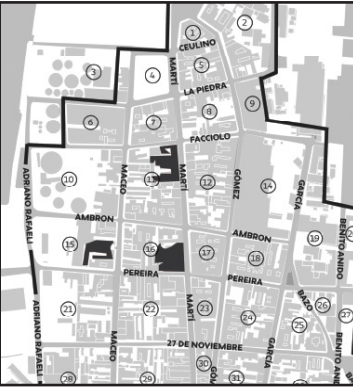
COLLAB

FINDINGS

GALLERY

Edificios / Buildings

LAYOUT TESTS



LAYOUT TESTS



DETAILS

